The object: what exists, and what we make

Verdict

Make one jewellery-scale locket for couples, and sell it as a locket, never as a "photo watch". Nothing like it surfaced in Korea, the US or the UK. The nearest products are $9 to $30 photo pocket watches for dads and groomsmen, and at the top a $149 mechanical watch with a photo holder.

So the design has to look different even in a thumbnail:

- **Smaller:** 36 mm, where photo watches run about 46 mm.
- **Hidden:** a colour photo inside, not a black-and-white etching on the lid.
- **Stopped:** hands fixed at your moment.
- **Written:** one line of each person's letter, in their own handwriting, inside the lid.

The first pieces start simpler, if the week-3 test finds the case: a stock hunter case of 40 mm or less, preferring 38 mm or less, with your pattern lasered on the lid and the handwriting printed. Closed, it looks like a small pocket watch, so every photo and video shows it open. If no such case exists, the Starting small tab sets out the fallbacks.

Price it in the band where Korean couples already spend. Mid-range couple rings cost ₩100,000 to ₩300,000 each, and people in their 20s call ₩100,000 to ₩130,000 a fitting anniversary gift, and spend about ₩271,600 on each anniversary (2023 survey). Lead with the pair at ₩139,000, next to the $85 to $140 pair price of long-distance bracelets such as Totwoo and Bond Touch.

Confidence that no direct competitor exists is medium-low. The search index covers Coupang, Naver Shopping and Kakao gifts poorly, so search those three by hand; it is on this week's list.

What already exists

Twenty products that set the look, the price and the expectations. There are no product photos here: the research tool could search the web but could not open pages, so it could not copy pictures. Tap a name to see the photos on the shop's own page; some names open a search page, so scroll for the item named. With five minutes, open these first: the Amazon photo watch (what to avoid), the Charles Hubert watch (the quality bar), the Abbott Lyon locket (the price and the secret engraving), the Idus mini locket (the Korean price) and Truest North (a needle that points to a place). Prices come from search results, not opened pages, and may have changed.

Product	What it is	Price	Take or avoid
Photo watch · Amazon photo pocket watches	About 46 mm, quartz, a black-and-white photo etched on the lid, sold for dads and groomsmen; dozens of near-identical listings	About $27	Avoid looking like this
Photo watch · Charles Hubert photo pocket watch	Mechanical hunter case with a photo holder and an engraved cover; the top of the photo-watch range	About $149	The bar for hinge, glass and finish
Photo watch · SHOWROOM photo pocket watch	47 mm corporate-gift photo watch on a stand; Korea's nearest item	₩59,000	The ceiling for anything called a "watch" in Korea
Photo watch · Idus pocket-watch pendants	Vintage pocket-watch pendant	₩28,000	The local look-alike
Locket · Abbott Lyon Photo Love Locket	Gold-plated steel locket with a photo and a secret engraving inside	From £89, about $118	The fashion-locket model; its secret engraving is our handwriting ring
Locket · Monica Rich Kosann lockets	Heirloom sterling lockets with two photos; the designer tier	$245 to $475	Lockets can be heirlooms
Locket · Lisa Angel photo locket	Plated locket; the buyer emails a photo; 1.4M+ orders on its storefront	£8 photo add-on	Collect and crop photos online for the buyer
Locket · silkpursesowsear brass locket	Solid brass with the photo on the metal		The material reference: warm, vintage, handmade

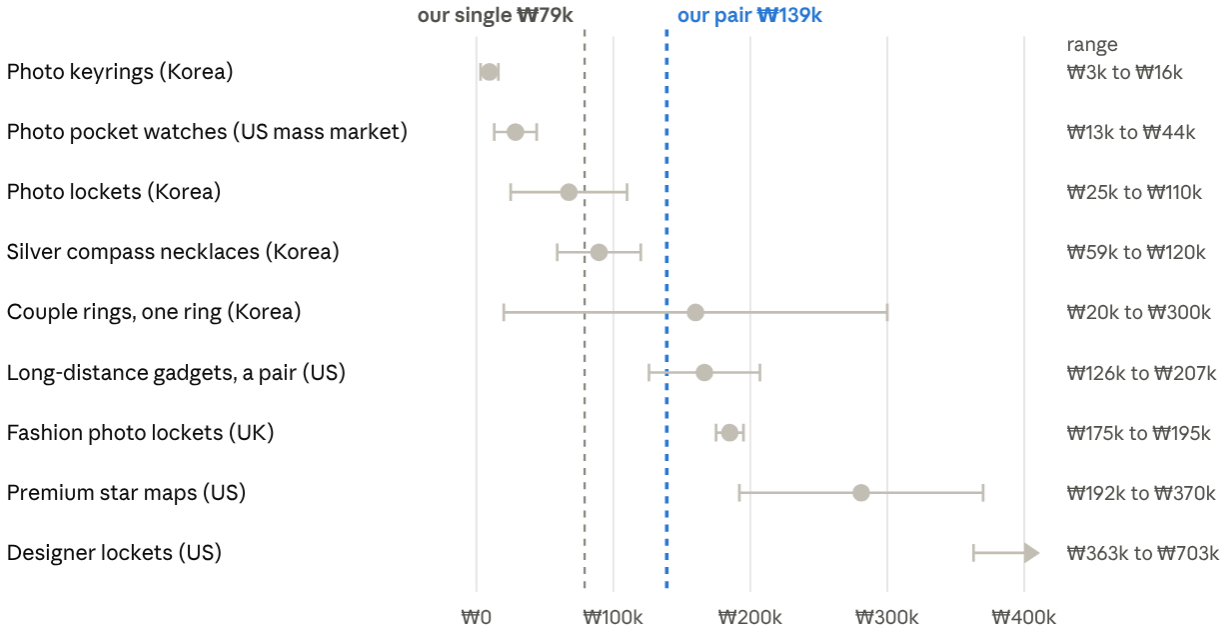
Product	What it is	Price	Take or avoid
Locket · Idus mini photo locket	Mini locket with photo and engraving, made in 4 to 6 days; sellers warn the snap is fragile	About ₩25,000	A sturdy hinge is a selling point
Compass · "I'd be lost without you" necklaces	Small compass pendant sold on a message card; a Walmart best-seller tag	$13 to $80	Romantic compasses still point north
Compass · Truest North	GPS compass whose needle points to a place you choose; Kickstarter and press	From $180	Proof that "points to a place" sells; ours needs no battery
Compass · Korean silver compass necklaces	925 silver vintage compass pendants	₩59,000 to ₩120,000	The local compass price
The moment · The Night Sky	The sky over a chosen place on a chosen date; 10.1K Trustpilot reviews	$39 print	A frozen moment sells; show a live preview before payment
The moment · Under Lucky Stars	Premium star maps	$130 to $250	A premium holds when the object is computed from the couple's own data
The moment · Korean constellation frames	Zodiac templates, not a real date and place	₩14,000 to ₩59,500	No date-accurate sky in Korea yet
Long distance · Lovebox	A box whose heart spins when a message arrives; 85,000+ of the classic sold, about €6M revenue in 2020	$130 to $175, plus $4.99 a month	Couples pay for an object plus a ritual
Long distance · Totwoo touch bracelets	Bracelets that light and buzz when the other is touched	$85 to $140 a pair	The pair-price anchor; needs charging

Product	What it is	Price	Take or avoid
Korean couples · Couple rings	Entry and mid-range brands such as 로이드; the main couple-jewellery budget	₩20,000 to ₩300,000 a ring	The budget we compete with
Military couples · 곰신 letter paper	Letter paper with both names, by service branch; many reviews, and a military-couple app sells its own	₩5,500	Military couples already buy things for their letters, but cheap ones
Charms · Photo keyrings	Acrylic photo charms, some with NFC	₩3,000 to ₩16,000	Charms are cheap; ours must read as jewellery

Where the gap is

At ₩139,000, the pair sits with couple rings and long-distance gifts

Price range for each kind of product, in won; US and UK prices converted



search results, Oct 2026 · listing price ranges, not averages · ₩1,480 to the dollar, £1 ≈ $1.33 · designer lockets run off the scale to ₩703k

The gap is not a price; it is a product. Nobody sells a jewellery-scale locket that is computed from a couple's own moment, the way star maps are, and nobody joins a keepsake to a letter that opens only when both have written. Photo watches are cheap

because they are generic, and the pair can charge couple-ring prices only if it never looks generic.

Our design: one small body, two faces, a sealed card

These are concept renders drawn for this plan, not photographs of a made sample. The samples decide the final piece.



Open, the lid holds your own photo under domed glass, ringed by one line from each of your letters, engraved in each person's own handwriting. The face holds the moment, its hands stopped at 11:11 or at the time you choose. That ring of handwriting is what makes the letter part of the object, and it is what a copycat can't make.



stopped at your moment
hands fixed at 11:11, or the time you choose

it points to you
a fixed needle set to the bearing of their city

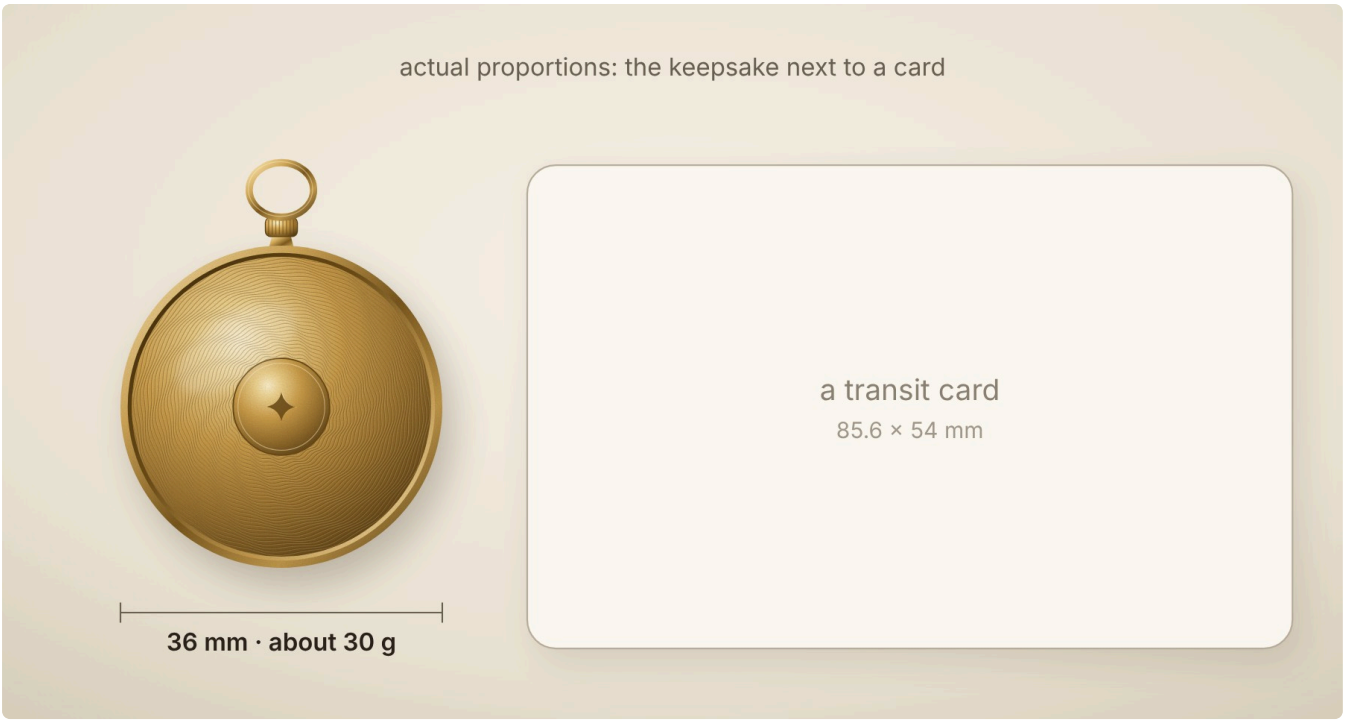
Two faces on one body. The watch face suits most couples. The needle face is for distance: it is set to the bearing from your city to theirs.



the lid
engine-turned brass, quiet from the outside

the back
one engraved line, and the sky that night

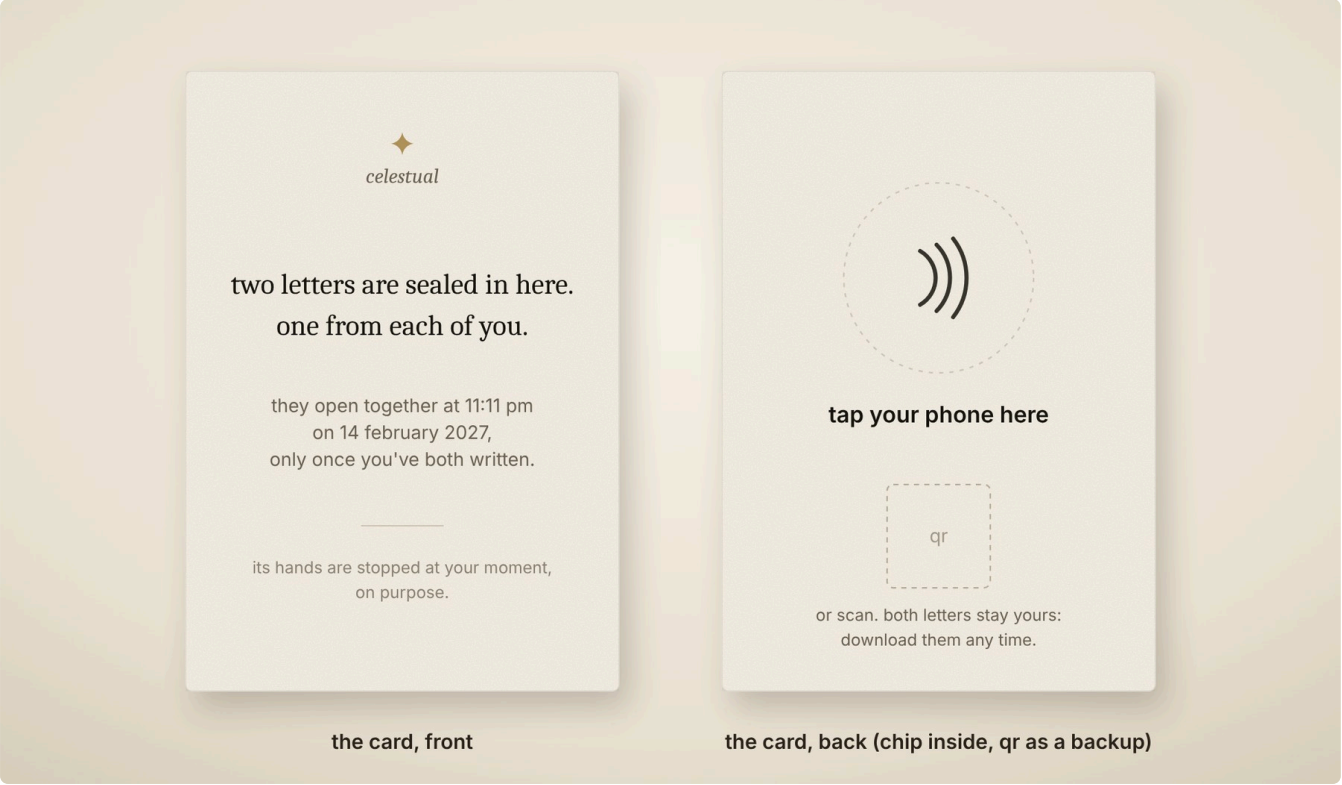
Outside, the lid is engine-turned brass. The back carries one engraved line and the sky over your city that night; the stars drawn here are illustrative.



Size: 36 mm across and about 30 g, small enough for a bag charm or a necklace.



The box opens in three beats: the box, the sealed letters, the click of the lid. That is also the shot list for every unboxing video.



the card, front — the card, back (chip inside, qr as a backup)

The card explains why the hands don't move, and holds the chip that opens both letters online, with the QR as a backup.

The first pieces start simpler. They use the smallest stock hunter case a factory already makes, if the tests find one, with your pattern lasered on the lid and the two handwritten lines printed around the photo; see Starting small. The spec below is the custom case they grow into.

Part	Spec	Why
Case	Brass hunter case, 34 to 38 mm, about 30 g, hinged at 9 o'clock	Light enough for a bag; quiet outside, antique inside
Finish	Hand-patinated brass under a clear e-coat (the base cost), or a silver-tone, nickel-free plating of 1 to 2 microns for about ₩2,000 to ₩4,000 more; lead at most 0.009%, Korea's limit for metal jewellery, and cadmium under 0.01% in every metal part, tested for nickel release	The content test picks between the two finishes
Dial	Cream, Roman numerals, blued hands glued at the chosen time; no movement	No battery to die, $2 to $5 cheaper, about 3 mm thinner

Part	Spec	Why
Photo	The couple's own, trimmed like a photo-booth frame, under domed mineral glass; the window is about 26 to 30 mm, so the crop guide must fit two faces	No printing, no photo moderation, and it can be swapped after a breakup
Inside the lid	One line from each person's letter, laser-engraved in their own handwriting, around the photo. No quote yet; if it isn't legible on a sample, the two lines go on a printed card behind the photo	Joins the free letter to the paid object; a copy can't engrave your partner's sealed words
Back	One engraved line; the back has room for 3 to 4 lines of about 20 Latin letters, or 2 lines of 10 to 12 Hangul. The sky is an option	The personal part, done in Seoul
Chain	Short chain with a trigger clasp	Switches between bag charm and necklace
Box	Matte black drawer box, cream insert, wax-sealed envelope	Three beats on camera, no glare
Card	Paper card with an NFC chip and a QR backup	A metal case blocks the chip, so it lives in the card

Decisions still open, and what settles each

One is already made: it is sold as a locket, not a watch. The rest are decided by a test, not by taste.

Decision	Options	Settled by	When
Price of the pair	₩119,000 or ₩139,000	The pair test shows each price at random, if the lawyer allowed sign-ups; compare taps. Otherwise the Wadiz waitlist decides after discharge	31 Jan

Decision	Options	Settled by	When
The face	Watch stopped at your moment, or the needle that points to you	Which one earns more "where can I buy" comments and DMs per 1,000 views	Dec to Jan
The finish	Silver-tone, or hand-patinated brass	The same content test, one post each	Dec to Jan
Size	The smallest stock case between 30 and 40 mm to start, preferring 38 mm or less; 34, 36 or 38 mm when the custom case comes	Case samples in hand: does the photo window fit two faces? About 26 to 30 mm on the custom case	First samples
Handwriting inside	Printed around the photo on the stock case; laser-engraved once you own a fiber marker, or on the custom case	Legibility on a sample at that size, and its cost	First samples
An entry item	A ₩29,000 to ₩39,000 brass 11:11 charm for Pepero Day, 100 days and friends	A one-question poll of pair-letter users if the lawyer allowed sign-ups; otherwise the waitlist after discharge	Dec to Jan
The opening time for military couples	11:11 am on a weekend or holiday	Already decided by phone rules: soldiers can use phones only 18:00 to 21:00 on weekdays and 08:30 to 21:00 on weekends and holidays	Now

In Branch A there are no samples before discharge. The face and finish posts use the concept renders, each labelled "concept, not made yet", and run only if the lawyer allowed posts about the object. Otherwise these choices wait for the first samples after discharge.

Making, selling and shipping

Verdict

Seoul has no pocket-watch case makers, so the case comes from a Chinese factory. Test first the smallest empty hunter case one already sells: bought in tens, with your pattern lasered on the lid, as the Starting small tab sets out. Move to a semi-custom case at 100 to 300 pieces once the shop sells 40 orders a month. Everything personal is done in Seoul: the dial set to the couple's time, the photo, the engraving, the checks and the packing. The label will most likely still say "Made in China", because finishing in Seoul does not usually change where a product is from. Say "finished by hand in Seoul", never "made in Korea", unless customs confirms it.

By estimate, not quote, the stock case costs about ₩28,400 for a boxed single and ₩54,200 for a pair, and arrives 2 to 3 weeks after the order. The semi-custom case costs about ₩34,400 and ₩62,800. Built to the same spec, the two cost about the same, so the stock case's gain is its small minimum and the cash it saves. No supplier has quoted yet, and your own hours on each order are not counted. On the semi-custom case, the purchase order to 100 sellable pieces takes about eight weeks.

Two rules before any order. **Numbers in the order, not "lead-free":** lead at most 0.009% by weight in every metal part, Korea's limit for metal jewellery since 2024, cadmium under 0.01%, and nickel-free plating. Back them with the supplier's test report for the item. Then lab-test the first lot of each metal part from each supplier yourself, and one lot in three after that. Free-machining and many casting brasses hold 1.8 to 3.7% lead, and brass sold as lead-free can still be over a jewellery limit. **Nothing is ordered before discharge.**

Route	Cost per case	Time	Minimum	Verdict
S. A factory's stock hunter case, bought empty with your lid lasered on, finished in Seoul	About $3 to $6 (estimate)	2 to 3 weeks from the order	Not shown; ask for 10	Test first
A. Semi-custom brass case from a Chinese factory, finished in Seoul	About $4 to $8	About 8 weeks from order to 100 pieces	100 to 300	**Next, once the shop sells 40 orders a month**

Route	Cost per case	Time	Minimum	Verdict
B. Lost-wax casting in Jongno from your own 3D model	About ₩10,000 to ₩25,000, 2 to 4 times route A	12 to 16 weeks	No formal minimum	Later, for a shape only you own
C. Stock watch pendants from Alibaba	About $1.50 to $2.50	2 to 4 weeks	10 to 100	Prototypes only: it looks like the commodity, and Wadiz won't take it

Case prices are listing prices and estimates from search results, not quotes. The first real quotes replace them.

Who makes what

Get at least three quotes for each part. Prices exclude VAT; most are listing prices or estimates.

Part	Where	Minimum	Price at 100	Lead time
Empty hunter case, your lid lasered on	Pocket-watch case factories through Alibaba or Made-in-China	Not shown; ask for 10	$3 to $6 (estimate)	2 to 3 weeks, by express
Brass hunter case blank, semi-custom	Factories in Guangzhou or Yiwu through Alibaba or 1688, via a Korean buying agent	100 to 300	$4 to $8	3 to 5 weeks, plus a week of freight
Prototype kit: stock watch pendants and lockets	Alibaba, AliExpress, 1688	10 to 100	$1.50 to $2.50	2 to 4 weeks
Cream Roman dial	A Chinese dial printer, or printed in Seoul	10 to 50	$0.30 to $1.00	1 to 3 weeks

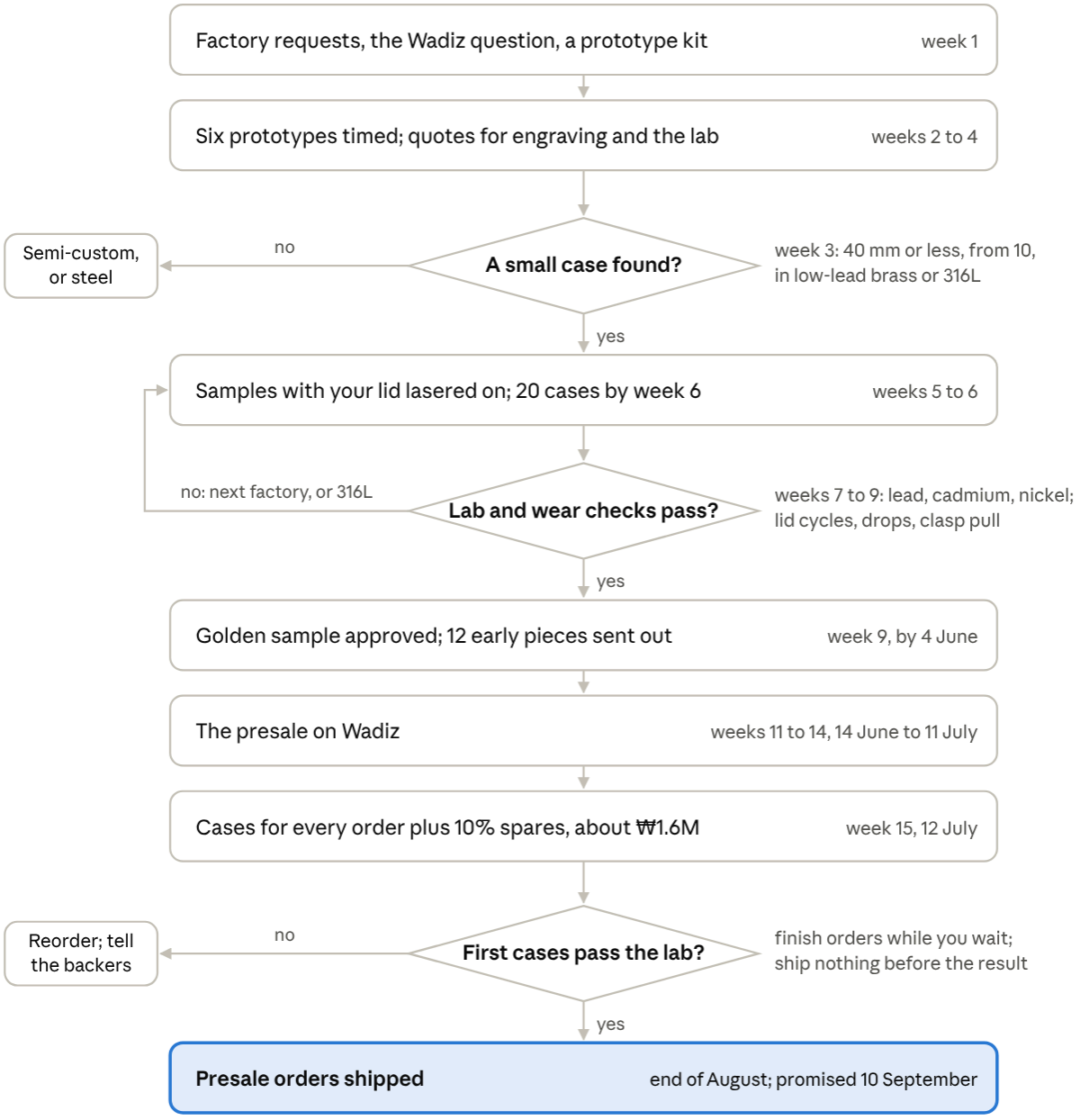
Part	Where	Minimum	Price at 100	Lead time
Fixed hands	Chinese watch-parts suppliers; parts dealers in Jongno 4-ga	About 100 pairs	$0.05 to $0.30 a pair	1 to 2 weeks
Domed glass, two per piece	China, or craft suppliers in Dongdaemun	10 to 100	₩100 to ₩500 each	Days to 2 weeks
Chain, trigger clasp and rings	The accessory-parts floor of Dongdaemun Jonghap Market	By the pack	₩1,000 to ₩3,500 a set	Days
Clear coat, or a thin gold flash	Plating shops in Jongno, or the factory	A lot minimum by weight	Coat ₩300 to ₩1,500; gold flash ₩2,000 to ₩4,000 more	3 to 7 days
Engraving, back and inside the lid	A Jongno 3-ga laser shop, or your own fiber marker: a generic 20 to 30 W one, about ₩1.5M to ₩3.5M including shipping, duty and VAT	1	₩5,000 to ₩12,000 a job (a regional blog); Soomgo's average ₩11,000; ₩2,000 to ₩6,000 only for 100 or more identical marks	Same day to 3 days
NFC chip (NTAG213)	nowwin, KOREA NFC	1	₩250 to ₩610	1 to 7 days
Letter card and envelope	Korean online printers	About 100	₩300 to ₩1,000 a set	3 to 7 days
Wax seal sticker	Sodastamp	1	₩350 to ₩460	About a week
Drawer box, custom	Packative, Betterbox, Box114 in Seoul; Bangsan market only from about 1,000	50 to 100	₩8,000 to ₩20,000	2 to 4 weeks

Part	Where	Minimum	Price at 100	Lead time
Drawer box, stock, with a printed sleeve	Seoul packaging wholesalers; the sleeve from an online printer	Not found	About ₩3,500 with the sleeve, by estimate; plain boxes list at ₩640 to ₩1,000	Days to 2 weeks, by estimate
Lab tests: lead, cadmium, nickel	KTR, KCL, KATRI, FITI or KOTITI	Per sample	₩150,000 to ₩400,000 per material, by estimate; no lab price was found. On the stock case, the first round, two cases plus a chain and a clasp, is about ₩0.6M to ₩1.6M, so budget ₩1M	1 to 3 weeks

Imported parts pay 8% Korean duty and 10% VAT on their value including freight. Goods for resale need a formal import declaration whatever their value. Bringing them in through the quick customs lane for personal parcels (목록통관) counts as smuggling. The Korea–China FTA lists 0% for chains. It covers the case only if the case's own line also shows 0% and the factory issues a certificate of origin, so ask the broker which line an empty watch case falls under.

From sample to the first pieces

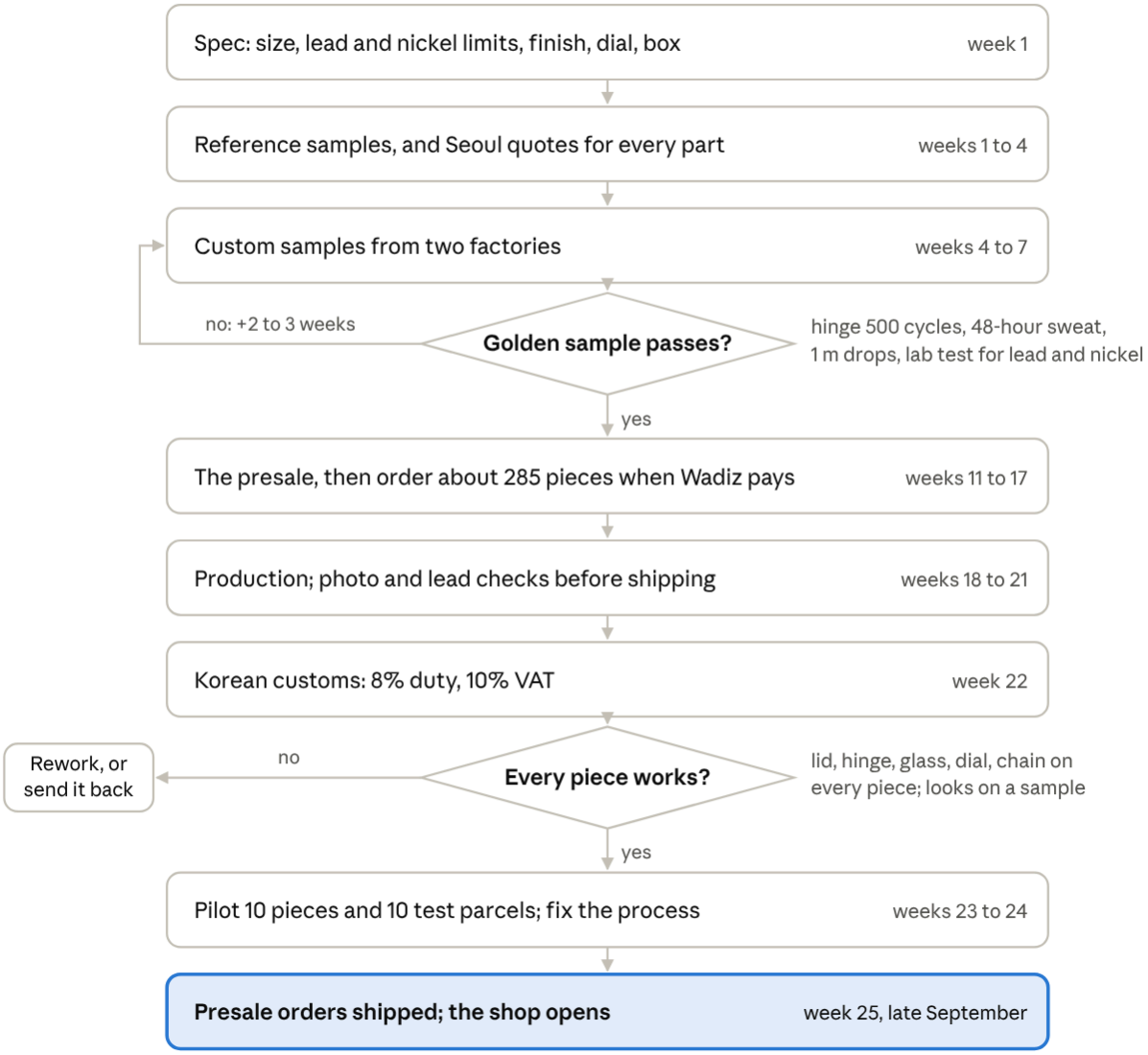
About 21 weeks from discharge to buyers' hands, with three checks on the way



the stock-case path · weeks counted from discharge, assumed early April 2027 · lead times from the sourcing research, not quotes

On the stock case, the gate in week 3 and the lab gate in weeks 7 to 9 decide whether the presale opens on 14 June. Cases are ordered the day after it closes and arrive in 2 to 3 weeks. The first are lab-tested on arrival, and presale orders ship by the end of August against a promise of 10 September. If the samples or the lab slip, the presale moves once, by up to four weeks.

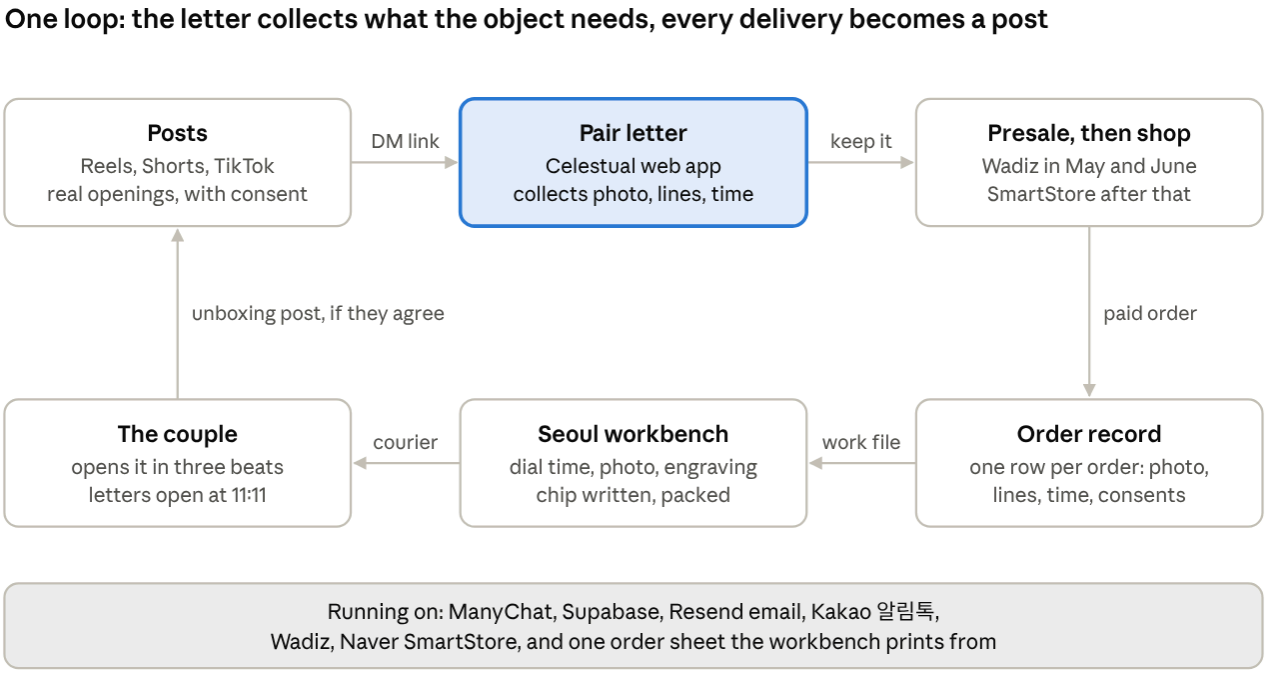
About 25 weeks from discharge to buyers' hands, with two checks that can send you back



production path · the semi-custom fallback, route A, weeks counted from discharge in early April 2027

The second chart shows the semi-custom case, the fallback, as if started in the week of discharge, early April 2027. Chosen at the week-3 gate instead, it runs two to three weeks later, and the presale and every date below move with it. The golden sample is approved in week 8, the presale runs from 14 June to 11 July, and the batch is ordered once Wadiz pays out, about two weeks later. With about eight weeks from order to finished pieces, the first pieces reach buyers in late September, and the presale page promises 8 October, two weeks to spare. Allow one extra sample loop of 2 to 3 weeks, and move every later date with it. Neither route starts before discharge: ordering earlier would mean a shop run for you while you serve.

The operations stack



operations loop · from the first post to the next post

The pair letter does the work competitors do by hand: it collects the photo, crops it to the window, records the time to set and the line each person wrote, and takes both people's consent. Each order then arrives at the workbench as one complete row, with nothing to chase by message. Supabase and Resend are already part of Celestual, so the only new systems are Wadiz, SmartStore and the order sheet. The order step itself is built in Phase 4, two weeks before the presale.

Shipping, returns and service

A boxed locket weighs about 150 to 300 g. Start with Korea Post or convenience-store parcels, and move to a fulfilment company only when packing takes more than a day a week.

Option	Price	When to use it
GS25 or CU half-price parcel, store to store	₩1,800 to ₩1,900 up to 500 g	Cheapest; the buyer collects from a convenience store
Korea Post counter	₩4,000	Home delivery at low volume
Courier contract for a small seller	About ₩2,500 to ₩3,500	Home delivery once volume is steady

Option	Price	When to use it
Fulfilment company, all-in (FASSTO and others)	₩2,700 to ₩3,500 an order	Past about 30 orders a week
Returns	₩3,000 each way; the seller pays for defects	

Service rules:

1. State the delivery date on every page and in every presale reward.
2. Answer within 24 hours; replace a defective piece first and ask questions later.
3. Take back defects for 3 months, and refund within 3 business days of the return arriving.
4. Delete the photo when the 3-month defect window closes, and say so before the upload.
5. Before payment, show the separate notice and the unticked consent box for personalised goods.

The US, later. Start on Etsy with 10 to 20 test orders, once there are 50 or more Korean reviews.

- **Shipping:** EMS costs about ₩23,000 to ₩26,000 for 0.5 kg, or from about ₩16,390 through a consolidator with duty prepaid.
- **Duty:** Korean-made goods have paid about 12.5% since 24 July 2026. A case made in China may still count as Chinese, which costs more.
- **Before the first US order,** get a free binding ruling from US Customs on the tariff code (imitation jewellery, 7117.19.90) and on origin.
- **A US fulfilment and engraving partner** makes sense only past 100 to 200 US orders a month.

Starting small: the first pieces from what already exists

Oct 18, 2026 · @Ace

Nobody makes our locket yet. The closest part on sale is an empty hunter case that pocket-watch factories sell for laser engraving. But no listing showed its size, metal, price or minimum. So the start is a test. Ask for a case of 40 mm or less, in low-lead brass or 316L steel, with your lid pattern lasered on. Buy it in tens and finish it in Seoul. If it exists at the estimated $3 to $6, it keeps the retro design. It also cuts the most cash you need at once, from about ₩7.2M to ₩4.9M. On cost per locket it only just meets the target: it misses above about ₩7,400 an engraving job, or about $4.95 a case. The generic photo pocket watch is cheaper to buy, and the wrong thing to sell.

The short answer

Your question	The answer
Is there a manufacturer already?	Not for our locket. No maker, wholesaler or print-on-demand platform sells a small brass hunter-case locket with no movement. The closest lead is one listing for an empty hunter case sold for laser engraving. It showed no size, metal, price or minimum, and it is probably the 45 mm alloy kind, so the week-3 answer may well be no. Working quartz pocket watches sell from 5 to 10 pieces, and Guangzhou brass makers take custom-logo orders from 2 to 30.
In what form?	An empty hunter case: crown, bow, hinged lid, crystal and a blank back, with no movement. The factory lasers your pattern on the lid. Seoul does the rest: your dial set to the couple's time, real hands, the photo, the engraving, the box and the letter.

Your question	The answer
Retro and customisable, or a generic stopwatch?	Retro and customisable. The generic photo watch is about 45 mm and quartz, with the photo lasered on the outer lid. It sells as a $20 to $90 groomsmen gift. It can carry about ₩45,000, not ₩79,000, and Wadiz won't take it.
Does it meet the cost target?	Only just, on the middle estimates: about ₩22,700 a locket against the ₩24,200 target, the cost the plan's prices were set on. Built to the same spec it is about ₩23,800, so the case itself saves only about ₩450. Most of the gap comes from printing the handwriting instead of engraving it. It misses above about ₩7,400 an engraving job, or about $4.95 a case; Soomgo's engraving average is ₩11,000. Your own fiber laser marker, a small engraving laser, cuts it to about ₩17,000, and the semi-custom case to about ₩17,600: the marker, not the case, is the big saving.
What does it change?	Cash, minimums and time, more than cost. Cases are bought from 10 for the orders in hand, so there is no batch of 285 to pay for. The most cash out at once falls from about ₩7.2M to ₩4.9M, and break-even from 104 presale orders to 85. Presale orders ship in August, not late September.
What could stop it?	Three things. No factory offers a case of 40 mm or less from 10 pieces. The case fails Korea's lead limit. Or Wadiz won't take a stock body as the reward. If lead is the only problem, use a 316L steel case. If no case exists, use the semi-custom case if about ₩9M is within reach, or else a round steel locket. If Wadiz refuses stock bodies, only the semi-custom case is left.

What already exists

Six forms come close. Prices are listing prices seen in search results, not quotes. Sizes and metals were rarely shown, so samples decide.

Form, with examples	Price and minimum	Fits the design?	Verdict
Generic photo pocket watch: Alibaba engravable pocket watches, Etsy groomsmen watches	$1.42 to $3.90, from 5 to 10; sold at $20 to $90	No: about 45 mm, alloy, quartz, the photo on the outer lid	Avoid
Watch-shaped photo locket, no movement: a flip-lid "pocket watch" photo pendant on 1688, China's domestic wholesale site; a Temu zinc-alloy pocket-watch locket	About ¥13, or ₩2,700	The shape, not the size or the metal; often zinc alloy	Prototypes only
Empty hunter case from a pocket-watch factory: one listing, a full-hunter empty case for laser engraving; dial printers from 1 to 10 pieces	Not shown. About $3 to $6 with your lid lasered on, by estimate	Yes, if a 30 to 40 mm size in low-lead brass or 316L exists	**Test first**
Round double-glass locket: Guangzhou IO Jewelry, 20, 25 and 30 mm, in 316 steel or gold-plated	$1 to $3, from 20 to 100	Partly: one window for the dial and one for the photo, but no crown, and a modern look	The fallback if cash is short
Small brass makers: Baoyan from 3 pieces, Mimier from 2, Peishang from 30	Not shown	Only if one already has a pocket-watch mould	Ask in week 1

Form, with examples	Price and minimum	Fits the design?	Verdict
Print-on-demand and Korean makers: Printify photo pendants, ShineOn, Idus photo lockets	$9 to $27 before shipping; ₩28,000 on Idus	No: flat pendants, small hearts and ovals	Avoid; Idus also bans bought-in (사입) and ODM goods

For the needle face, solid brass compass lockets list at $3 to $6 from 100 pieces. But a live needle can't be fixed on a city, so print or engrave the needle on the dial. Custom watch dials from hobby sellers cost $26 to $33 each, more than a whole locket's budget, so the dial is printed in Seoul.

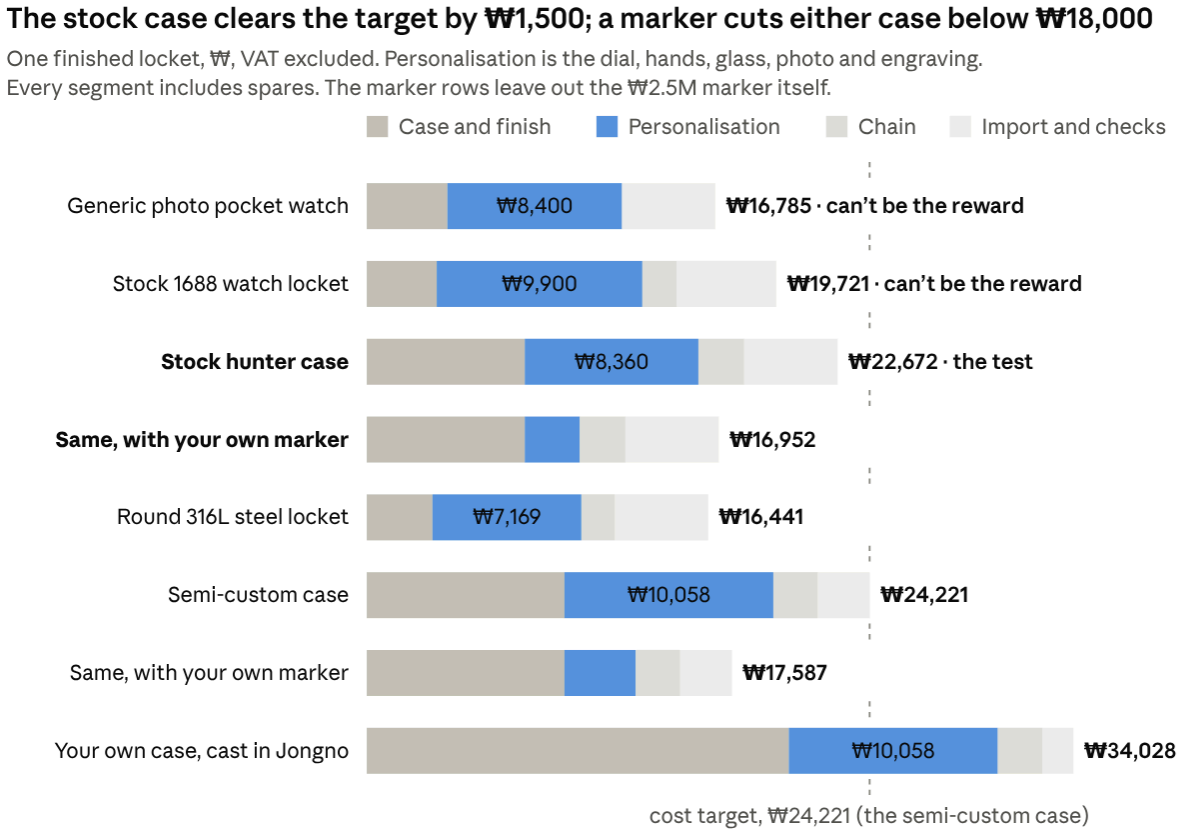
Retro, customisable or generic: six routes side by side

The stock hunter case is the cheapest route that is retro and customisable in tens. Whether Wadiz accepts it as the main reward is our reading of its rules, not Wadiz's answer, so ask Wadiz before ordering cases.

Route	Looks like Celestual	Minimum and time	Can be the Wadiz reward
Generic photo pocket watch	No	10 pieces, 2 weeks	No: the same watch is on sale everywhere
Stock 1688 watch locket	Partly: the shape	10 pieces, 3 weeks	No: the same item is on sale
Stock hunter case, your lid lasered on	**Yes, at 30 to 40 mm, preferring 38 mm or less**	**Not shown; ask for 10. About 3 weeks**	**Probably, if the page says how it is made. Ask Wadiz first**
Round 316L steel locket	Partly: no crown, and a modern look	20 to 100 pieces, 3 weeks	Only with your own mark and dial, and only if Wadiz accepts a stock body
Semi-custom case, the fallback	Yes: 36 mm, engine-turned	100 to 300 pieces, 8 weeks	Yes
Your own case, cast in Jongno	Yes: a shape only you own	No formal minimum; about 30 in the model. 12 to 16 weeks	Yes

- **What you can make your own:** on the generic watch, only its outer lid. On the 1688 and steel lockets, the dial, time, photo and engraving, and your mark on the steel one. On the stock hunter case, everything but its shape: lid, dial, time, photo, engraving, box and letter. The semi-custom and cast cases add the handwriting engraved inside the lid.
- **Metal and engraving:** the generic watch and the 1688 locket are often zinc alloy, the metal that fails Korea's limits most. Engraving through their plating shows grey. 316L steel is the safest metal and engraves cleanly. The stock hunter case must be low-lead brass or 316L, tested before sale.

What each route costs



docs/strategy/model/routes.py · listing prices and estimates, no supplier has quoted · 18 Oct 2026

Among the China routes, the case changes the cost by a few thousand won. Engraving, the box and your time are where the money goes. Only the Jongno cast case is dear.

Route	Single, boxed	Left per presale order: single, pair	Starting cost; break-even
Generic photo pocket watch, at ₩45,000 and ₩79,000, if Wadiz took it	₩19,500	₩6,900 and ₩15,300	₩2.5M; 138 orders

Route	Single, boxed	Left per presale order: single, pair	Starting cost; break-even
Stock 1688 watch locket	₩25,400	₩30,300 and ₩57,300	₩3.0M; 58 orders
Stock hunter case	**₩28,400**	**₩26,900 and ₩50,500**	**₩4.0M; 85 orders**
Round 316L steel locket	₩22,100	₩34,100 and ₩64,900	₩3.7M; 63 orders
Semi-custom case	₩34,400	₩20,000 and ₩40,500	₩4.0M; 104 orders
Your own case, cast in Jongno	₩44,200	₩8,600 and ₩17,900	₩3.6M; 176 orders

- **What is left:** the price less making, the Wadiz fee, shipping, defects and ₩7,000 an order for your own posts: props, gifts and tools. No VAT is due, as in the Economics tab. Every route but the generic watch is priced at ₩79,000 and ₩139,000.
- **Like for like:** built to the semi-custom spec, the stock case costs about ₩23,800 a locket and ₩34,000 a boxed single, against ₩24,200 and ₩34,400. That spec is the handwriting engraved, the custom box and the plan's engraving prices. Break-even is then about 102 orders, against 104.
- **The box:** the stock routes use a stock drawer box with a printed sleeve. With the card, chip, seal and pouch it costs about ₩5,700 a single, against ₩10,200 for the custom box. That ₩4,500 saving is an estimate, and it sits outside the per-locket figures; the custom box can come with the custom case.
- **Checks are priced in:** the small-lot routes carry ₩3,000 a locket for checks and lab re-tests, and ₩1M for the first round of lab tests.
- **What the stock case's ₩4.0M buys:**
  - April: the prototype kit and printing tools, ₩550,000; case samples by express, ₩300,000; the trademark, ₩546,000; registration, ₩50,000.
  - May: box samples and a sleeve proof, ₩50,000; the design registration of the lid and dial, ₩150,000; the lab tests, ₩1M.
  - June: the 12 early pieces, shipped, ₩360,000; photography, ₩200,000.
  - April to September: tools, ₩270,000.
  - On top: 15% for surprises, ₩521,400.
- **Cheapest is not allowed as is:** the 1688 locket can never be the reward, and the steel locket only with your own mark and dial, if Wadiz accepts a stock body.

- **What decides the cost target:** engraving first. It is ₩6,000 a job in the model. A regional blog puts a short line at ₩5,000 to ₩12,000, and Soomgo's average is ₩11,000. Above about ₩7,400 a job, the stock case misses the target; at ₩11,000, a locket costs about ₩28,200. The case price matters too: the target holds only up to about $4.95 a case, inside the $3 to $6 estimate. At $6 a locket costs about ₩25,900.
- **Your own fiber marker:** a generic 20 to 30 W engraving laser costs about ₩1.5M to ₩3.5M, including shipping, duty and VAT. Each job then costs a few hundred won, and a locket about ₩17,000. The handwriting can be engraved inside the lid again. The model's ₩2.5M marker pays back after about 245 orders. With its own marker the semi-custom case is about ₩17,600, so the marker, not the case, is the big saving.
- **When to buy the marker:** once Wadiz's first payout has landed and the first presale cases have passed the lab, if the presale has 100 orders or more, or 60 or more with a quote above ₩10,000 a job. Try it on the spare cases first, and keep the Jongno shop booked for the presale run.
- **Your time is not in these costs:** about 35 to 60 minutes a locket, so 100 presale orders take 90 to 150 hours. A helper for half those hours costs about ₩0.5M to ₩0.8M at the minimum wage, also outside the model.
- **Cash:**
  - The stock case pays for the presale's cases on the close, about two weeks before Wadiz's first payout lands, by our estimate. So it is most out of pocket in mid-July, about ₩4.9M.
  - That counts only the cases. Buy the chains, boxes, cards and other parts after the payout lands; they take days to two weeks.
  - The dip grows with the presale, by about ₩160,000 for each 10 orders above 100. Above about 135 orders, ask the factory for a deposit on the close and the balance on shipping.
  - The semi-custom case orders its batch once the payout lands, and is most out at the end of September, about ₩7.2M.
  - Keep about ₩9M within reach until the gates pass in early June, then about ₩5.5M until December, as in the Economics tab. The stock case with the marker bought in August needs about ₩5.2M at a 60% payout.
  - The stock case is back above zero in October, or November with the marker; the semi-custom case in December.
- **If the presale fails:** about ₩3.4M is lost on either route. If Wadiz charged 25 backers anyway, the loss is about ₩2.2M instead of ₩3.1M, because there is no 100-case minimum to buy. The custom box's minimum would add to the semi-custom loss.

The rules that decide it

1. **Wadiz won't take a product that is already on sale.** Its review policy rules out a main reward whose identical product was sold or pre-sold before submission through another official channel, in Korea or abroad. The page must also say how the reward is made. In 2019 a toothbrush found on Taobao at a tenth of the price had its funding ended early. Since 2021 Wadiz also checks that the maker planned and developed the item, and checks its appearance. So:
   - a stock 1688 locket, even engraved, is a prototype, never the reward;
   - the reward is new where people look: your lid, your dial, the stopped time, the photo, the engraving, the box and the letter;
   - the page says "case made by a partner factory in China to our lid design; dial printed, hands set, photo fitted, engraving and assembly by hand in Seoul";
   - nothing is sold or pre-sold anywhere before the Wadiz submission, SmartStore and Instagram included;
   - whether a stock body passes is our reading, not Wadiz's answer, so ask Wadiz in writing in week 1.
2. **Korea bans metal jewellery with more than 0.009% lead** (90 mg/kg), for imports since July 2024 and for sales since January 2025. Cadmium of 0.1% or more is banned too, and nickel release is held to 0.5 µg/cm² a week. The lead and cadmium limits are in the environment ministry's restricted-substance notice under the chemicals law (화평법). The ministry was renamed in October 2025, so read the current notice on law.go.kr. The nickel limit is reported by the press; its legal source was not found. The limits bind both the importer and the seller.
   - That is stricter than the 0.05% this plan used until now, and ordinary brass is far above it.
   - Cheap marketplace jewellery fails often: 96 of 404 AliExpress and Temu pieces at Incheon customs in 2024, at 10 to 700 times the limits.
   - So a Korean test lab checks the first lot of each metal part from each supplier before anything is sold. That costs an estimated ₩150,000 to ₩400,000 per material.
   - After that, keep the supplier's report for every lot. Lab-test one lot in three, and any lot after a change of supplier, alloy or plating. Buy chains and clasps 200 at a time, so they are tested rarely.
3. **Imports for resale need a formal declaration.** Bringing in goods you sell through the quick customs lane for personal parcels (목록통관) counts as smuggling. Import under the business number and pay 8% duty plus 10% VAT. The Korea–China FTA lists 0% for

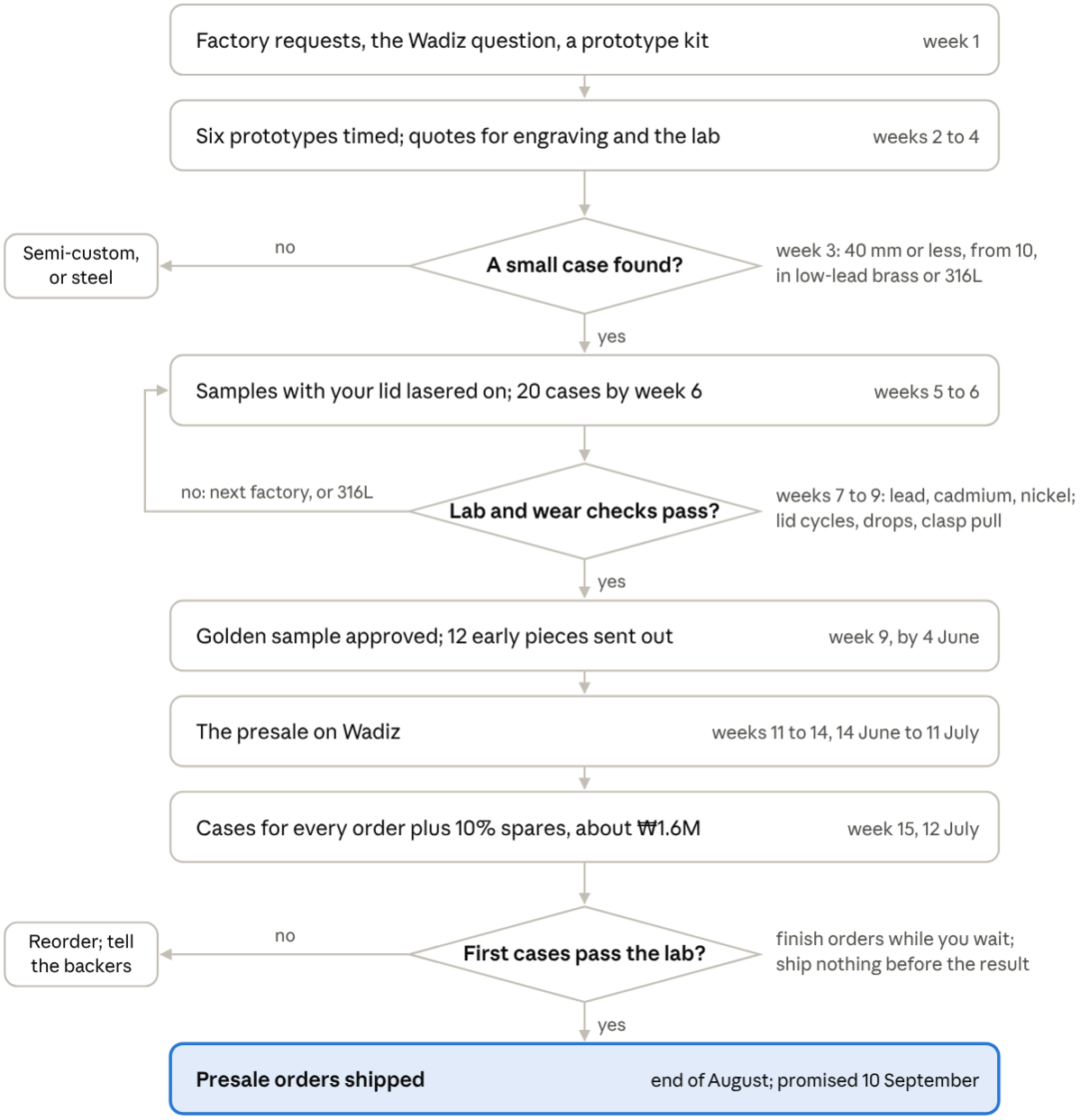
chains. It covers the case only if the case's own line also shows 0% and the factory issues a certificate of origin. Ask the broker which line an empty watch case falls under. Mark "Made in China" on the tag or the box, and say "finished by hand in Seoul".

4. **Wadiz pays 60 to 80% when the funding's payments complete,** by its guide, and the rest after the last delivery and the refund process. Run the presale as reward funding (펀딩) with a goal, not as Wadiz's pre-order type (프리오더). A pre-order needs a special benefit, and its special-bundle and limited-edition versions are paid only afterwards. Confirm the split for your project; the model assumes 70%.
5. **Not Idus or Tumblbug.** Idus bans bought-in (사입) and ODM goods (made to a factory's own design), inspects workshops, and removes sellers who break the rule. Tumblbug bars projects that buy goods to pass on.

From discharge to the first shipments

Weeks count from discharge, assumed early April 2027. Nothing is ordered before it. The presale stays at 14 June to 11 July only if the samples pass on time. If they slip, move it once, by up to four weeks, as the plan allows. These weeks also hold the business registration, the waitlist push, both IP filings, the first in-person 11:11 night and the order-step build. If they overrun, move the 11:11 night to after the presale first.

About 21 weeks from discharge to buyers' hands, with three checks on the way



the stock-case path · weeks counted from discharge, assumed early April 2027 · lead times from the sourcing research, not quotes

1. **Week 1, by 9 April:**
   - Send the requests in the next section to five pocket-watch case factories and three Guangzhou brass makers.
   - Ask two semi-custom case factories for a quote at 100 pieces, so the fallback doesn't start from zero at week 3.
   - Ask Wadiz in writing whether a stock body can be the main reward: a stock hunter case with your lid, dial, photo and engraving, or a stock round steel locket with your mark, dial and photo. Ask about both in one message, and ask how long its review takes and whether the waitlist page needs it first.

- Have the lid file ready, and a draft supply agreement to send the chosen factory. Wadiz has asked makers whose design a factory produces (OEM) for both.
- Order a prototype kit: two or three each of four stock bodies, plus real watch hands, glass domes, 25 and 30 mm circle punches and UV glue. The bodies are a generic photo watch to compare against, the 1688 watch locket, a small pendant watch and a 30 mm steel locket. About ₩550,000 with the printing tools.
- AliExpress items on 5 to 7 day delivery come first; the rest takes 2 to 4 weeks.
- The lid and dial files must be ready. If the lawyer did not allow design work before discharge, add a week.

2. **Weeks 2 to 4:** build six prototypes as the kit arrives, and time every step. Compare a printed dial with real hands against a fully printed one, try the needle face, and check that two faces fit the photo window. Get a fixed price per job from a Jongno 3-ga engraver, and quotes from two customs brokers for a small formal import. Ask a Korean test lab, KTR, KCL or FITI, for a quote.
3. **Week 3, the gate, by 23 April:** does any factory offer a hunter case of 40 mm or less from 10 pieces? It must be brass with a stated lead content under 0.009%, or 316L steel. If yes, order samples with your lid lasered on from the best two, about ₩300,000 by express.
   - If no case exists, use the semi-custom case if you can keep about ₩9M within reach, and move the presale back about three weeks, which uses its one move. Otherwise use the round steel locket.
   - If the only problem is lead, go to steel: a custom brass case has the same problem.
4. **Weeks 5 and 6:** the samples arrive. Check the dial seat, the photo recess in the lid, the hinge and the snap. Send one of each, with a chain and a clasp, to the lab. Photos of the real prototype, labelled 시제품, replace the concept renders on the waitlist page.
   - If Wadiz has said yes, order 20 cases from the better factory, about ₩170,000: 10 for creators, a pair to film, and spares. Ask the factory to confirm they are the same alloy and plating as the sample.
   - If Wadiz hasn't answered by week 5, chase it. With still no answer by week 6, order the 20 anyway: ₩170,000 is the price of keeping 14 June.
5. **Weeks 7 to 9, the second gate: the lab result.** The case, chain and clasp must pass.
   - If the better factory's case fails, use the second factory's if it passed, and reorder the 20 cases from it. If both fail, order and test a 316L case. Move the presale back once, by up to four weeks, if the early pieces can't go out in time.
   - Build the golden sample, the finished piece every later one must match. Run the plan's wear checks: 500 open-and-close cycles, three 1 m drops, heat and cold, and a 3 to 5 kg pull on the clasp.

    - Submit the project to Wadiz's review with the sample photos as soon as the lab passes, so a no at review still leaves time to move the presale once.
6. **Week 9, by 4 June:** approve the golden sample and send out the 12 early pieces.
7. **The presale, 14 June to 11 July.** If the goal is met, order cases for every presale order on 12 July, plus 10% spares, about ₩1.6M; they arrive in 2 to 3 weeks. Send the first presale cases to the lab the day they arrive. Finish orders while you wait, but ship nothing until the result is in.
8. **From late July:** personalise the presale orders. That is 90 to 150 hours of work, so the helper you lined up by March starts on day one. Ship by the end of August; the page promises 10 September. Then, each month, order the next month's cases.
9. **Move to the semi-custom case** once the shop sells 40 orders a month, or once reviews name the stock case as the weak point. It is 36 mm, with an engine-turned lid and the handwriting engraved inside. Pay its 100-piece minimum from sales, not savings.

What to send suppliers

To pocket-watch case factories, through Alibaba or Made-in-China, in week 1:

```
Request for quotation: empty hunter pocket-watch case, no movement
- Full-hunter case, the smallest you make between 30 and 40 mm (38 mm or less
preferred): crown and bow, hinged front lid with a snap, crystal fitted, back
left blank
- Inside the case: a seat or spacer ring for a printed dial with no movement,
and a centre post for fixed hands
- Inside the front lid: a flat recess for a 25 to 30 mm photo under flat or
low-domed glass; tell us its depth and the gap to the crystal
- Material: brass with lead below 0.009% (90 mg/kg) and cadmium below 0.01%
by weight (the EU limit), in the base metal, plating and solder; or 316L
stainless steel
- A test report for this item: lead and cadmium content, and nickel release
(EN 1811)
- Our pattern laser-engraved on the front lid, from our vector file; our mark
inside the back cover, not the lid
- Finish: polished brass under clear lacquer, no nickel under-plate
- Measurements and photos with a ruler: diameter, thickness, lid recess,
crystal and weight
- Prices at 10, 50 and 100 pieces; sample price and time with our engraving;
production time
- Our lid pattern is ours: do not sell it to others, and sign a short supply
agreement that says so
- Individual bags; a commercial invoice stating the country of origin; a
Korea-China FTA certificate of origin, if you can issue one
```

To the Guangzhou brass makers: do you already have a pocket-watch-shaped photo locket mould? Can you make it in brass with lead below 0.009%, at 30 to 50 pieces, with our lid pattern?

In Seoul, in week 2:

```
[각인] 황동 또는 316L 스테인리스 회중시계형 펜던트 뒷면 1줄 레이저 각인, 지름 30~40 mm (38 mm 이하 우선), 벡터 파일 제공. 문구는 개당 다름(개별 각인). 10개 / 50개 / 100개 기준 건당 단가와 소요 기간을 알려주세요.
[시험] 금속 장신구 납·카드뮤 함량 및 니켈 용출(EN 1811) 시험: 케이스 2종, 체인 1종, 고리 1종. 수수료와 기간을 알려주세요.
[통관] 중국산 금속 장신구 소량 일반수입신고(사업자 통관) 건당 수수료를 알려주세요. 빈 회중시계 케이스(무브먼트 없음)의 HS 분류(7117.19 또는 9111)와 한중 FTA 협정세율도 알려주세요.
```

Risks, and what to do

Risk	The sign	What to do
No small case exists	Week-3 replies offer only 45 mm cases, or zinc alloy	The semi-custom case at 100 pieces if about ₩9M is within reach, moving the presale about three weeks; or the steel locket
Wadiz says no to a stock body	Its answer in weeks 1 to 6, or at review	The semi-custom case if about ₩9M is within reach, and move the presale. The steel locket only if Wadiz's answer allows its body
The case fails the lead test	A lab result over 0.009%	The second factory's case if it passed, or a 316L case; sell nothing from the failed lot
The case can't hold the photo or the dial	The samples in weeks 5 and 6	Ask the factory for a lid recess and a dial seat; if it can't, the next factory or the steel locket
The presale lot fails the lab	A result over 0.009% in August	Ship nothing from it. Reorder from the second factory, tell backers the new date, and refund anyone who asks

Risk	The sign	What to do
Customs holds a lot for testing	A customs notice, or a lot that is late	Keep the supplier's report and your lab result with the import papers; the promise date has 10 days to spare
A backer finds the case on AliExpress	A comment, a DM, or a question from Wadiz	The page already says where the case is made and what is yours; answer with that, and never deny it. Wadiz has ended projects over this, so have its written view before you submit
Engraving costs more than ₩6,000 a job	The Jongno quote in week 2	Above about ₩7,400 a job, the stock case misses the cost target. Buy the fiber marker by the rule under "When to buy the marker"
Stock cases vary	Loose hinges, weak snaps, crystals off centre	Check every piece, and buy 10% spares
The work runs slow	Under 8 orders finished a day in the first week; that pace is 7 to 12 hours a day for one person	Two people from the first day. A helper for half the hours costs about ₩0.5M to ₩0.8M at the minimum wage; the promise date has 10 days to spare

Sources

Search results read on 18 October 2026, not opened pages. The full notes are in docs/strategy/research/F-starting.md, and the costs come from docs/strategy/model/routes.py.

- Wadiz: reward review policy · fee and settlement policy · the notice on OEM rewards · stricter review from 2021, ktnews · the toothbrush ended early, etnews 2019
- Metal limits: Korea's 0.009% lead limit, ChemLinked · Gunsan customs tests, Tax Times · Incheon customs tests, Aju News
- Import: the personal-parcel lane for resale counts as smuggling, Taxwatch · the FTA rate for 7117.19
- Other platforms: Idus selling rules · Tumblbug project rules

- Personalisation: engraving prices, Soomgo · fiber laser marker listings · engraving plated zinc alloy, Sourcify

The 11:11

Verdict

The group 11:11 stays as the free format and the brand's origin, but it is no longer the whole company. It runs only when a host commits in writing, it costs $0, and it is the test most plausibly legal while you serve, once the lawyer says so in writing.

Inside the master plan it has three jobs:

1. **Prove the format** in a closed group, against gates written in advance (the turnaround memo's Gate 1 and Gate 2).
2. **Make pairs.** A two-way "i like you" or "closer friends" is the start of a pair, and the pair letter is its natural next step: offered after the night, never during it.
3. **Feed content and hosts.** Group recaps, shared with consent, bring the next group.

It is not a sales channel. Nothing is sold during a night, picks are never paid, and no romantic claim is made in marketing until Gate 2 says the romance is real.

The name is not Korean. 11:11 is the minute people make a wish everywhere. Korean student associations were only the cheapest first pilot, because you know their officers and 11.11 is Pepero Day. English labels are the default; Korean labels appear only for Korean groups.

How a night works

1. **A host commits in writing** to a night for a group with an active roster of 60 or more, with two named contacts.
2. **Save the date, then rehearse.** The host posts only a save-the-date. The join link reaches the group chat only after a rehearsal with 20 to 30 testers passes.
3. **Join.** A secret link, used once and tied to the member's Instagram account. Members give a birth year, 18 or older, or 19 for Korean groups, type a first name and last initial, and give an email for the result.
4. **Pick names, no text, in three kinds:**
   a. *thanks*: signed, up to 10, always delivered
   b. *closer friends*: sealed, up to 3
   c. *i like you*: sealed, up to 2
5. **Writing closes at 10:11 pm.** At 11:11 pm local, a sealed pick opens only if both chose the same kind for each other, privately, on the page and by email.

6. **Everyone opens something.** Officers make sure every member receives at least one signed thank-you, so nobody sees a bare zero.
7. **After.** The numbers the gates need are saved at 71 hours. One-way picks are deleted at 72 hours, and two-way pairs are anonymised after 14 days.

The full rules, including who can see what, safety and the one-person version, are in the turnaround memo, section "The one thing to build: 11:11, version 0".

Gates carried over from the turnaround memo

Gate 0, the live check, the pair-test bars and the switching rule go to the outside gatekeeper by 16 October and are frozen then; the night gates from the rehearsal on are frozen on 5 November. Nobody changes a threshold after that.

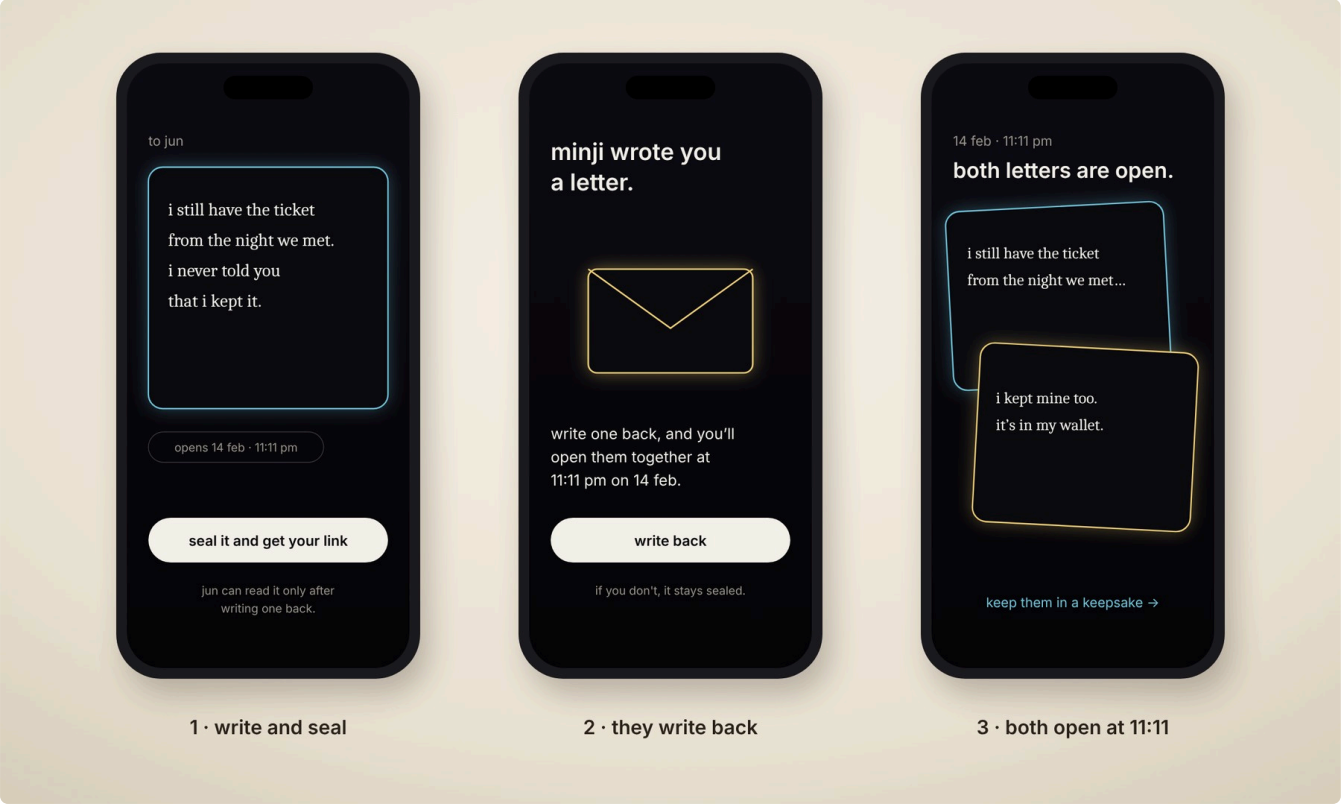
Gate	When	Passes if	Otherwise
Legal	21 Oct 2026	A written yes to free activity (Branch A)	No written answer yet, or barred: dormant until the answer or discharge (Branch 0). Gate 0 is held four days after the written yes
Gate 0: hosts	25 Oct, 21:00 KST	A host committed in writing to 11 November (roster 60 or more, two contacts), 3 hosts dated by 20 November, and the lawyer permits it	Any other case with one written host: nights from 20 November, which report results but decide nothing. No host: no nights in 2026, and pair letters start the next day
Live check	1 Nov	Joining and picking work in production, 3 hosts committed	The pilot moves to 20 November
Rehearsal	6 Nov, decided 8 Nov	80% of 20 to 30 testers join within 5 minutes, the reveal is on time	The pilot moves to 20 November
Gate 1: does remote hosting work?	10 days after the third night	3 nights of 25 or more; a median 35% of the roster joins; 40% send a sealed pick; half say "do it again"	Median under 25%, or "do it again" under 35%: remote hosting stops, and in person becomes the next test

Gate	When	Passes if	Otherwise
Gate 2: does the romance work?	1 Mar 2027	650 or more clean "i like you" picks, 10 or more clean pairs, at least 1.5 times as many mutual pairs as random picking would give, with the random count doubled to be safe	"Not proven yet": no romance-led marketing. At 1.2 times random or less, the romantic layer comes off
Is the format real?	June 2027	Groups rebook without being pitched and run nights without founder help	
Is it a company?	13 Dec 2027	40 or more groups ran a night, half with no founder help	Below the bar: the 11:11 runs as seasons, not as the company. Celestual is a side project only if the shop gate in February fails too

"Clean" leaves out the team, the officers, test links and couples who were already together. The first in-person night after discharge runs whatever the remote result, because in person is the real launch and has to be tested before anyone decides the company's fate.

One engine, two products

The group 11:11 and the pair letter are the same machine: something sealed, opened at 11:11 only when both sides have acted. Build it once; whichever test runs first pays for most of the other.



Concept screens for the pair letter, in the brand's existing night palette.

	Group 11:11	Pair letters
Who	Members of one closed group	Two people who already know each other
What is sealed	A pick: a name, in one of three kinds	A letter
It opens when	Both picked the same kind for each other	Both have written
When	11:11 pm on the group's night	11:11 pm on the date the pair chose, or 11:11 am on a weekend or holiday when either serves
If it isn't mutual	Nobody is told; one-way picks are deleted at 72 hours	The letter stays sealed and is deleted after 30 days
Shared code	Joining and age check, sealing, the timed reveal, the result email, deletion jobs, analytics	The same
Built only for it	The directory, the three kinds, officer tools	The share link, the date picker, the "keep it in an object" question if the lawyer allows it

If the pair letter is built first (no host at Gate 0), it takes 10 to 15 hours, and the 11:11 later reuses its sealing, reveal and deletion. If the pilot night goes first, the pair letter becomes an add-on of a few hours.

Unlocking only when both answer is not new. SumOne, Korea's leading couple app with about 1M daily users, shows each partner's daily answer only once both have answered. What no one offers is one sealed letter that opens at 11:11 on a date the pair picks, then becomes a brass object with both people's handwriting inside. So compete on the time lock and the object, don't add daily questions, and treat SumOne as a possible partner.